No Child Left Behind

with poems by RedLipsandTattoos, Dominique Christina and Denice Frohman

No Child Left Behind Leaves Entire Schools Behind by RedLipsandTattoos (pen name)

One morning a prominent, well-to-do, Caucasian man, who most likely attended private schools, woke up with the idea for the No Child Left Behind Act.

INTRODUCTION

It was 2002, and the No Child Left Behind Act (NCLB) was a well-intentioned piece of bipartisan legislation with the primary aim of ensuring equitable educational opportunities for all students in the American public education system. However, it was devised without consideration for how it might actually harm the public-school experience. Subsequently, NCLB currently operates with many fundamental flaws that damaged American public education. Simply put, "No Child Left Behind" forced many schools to focus on budgetary constraints instead of the education of students. Even though "No Child Left Behind" was repealed in 2015, it serves as a prime example of how a body of law with the right intentions can negatively impact others simply by its execution.

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These two poems, No Child Left Behind Leaves Entire Schools Behind by RedLipsandTattoos and No Child Left Behind by Dominique Christina & Denice Frohman, detail the injustices of the American education system while recognizing the flaws in the academic slogan "No Child Left Behind." They address the communities that are often left out of education in America.

No Child Left Behind Leaves Entire Schools Behind Continued . . .

At first, everyone in this little country you may have heard of, called the U.S.A., thought the idea was just brilliant. They figured it wouldn't affect the private school children, and since a rich, smart Caucasian man thought it up, everyone was certain it would benefit all public-school children, even the low-income African-American girls! They had a lot of faith in the new act.

As each year passed, and more places instated the act, in hopes no child would be left behind, school districts began receiving complaints from parents. What audacity these parents must have, complaining that this wonderful act was leaving their child behind!

These parents made outrageous claims. In one state in particular, that was having an especially tough time, called

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Oregon, the most outrageous claims were made. Parents and students alike came together, and many realized that students were being given unnecessary tests, that don't truly gauge a school's success. Schools that were doing just fine were suddenly being torn to shreds, and losing students, as well as funding, because their students didn't do wonderful on one test, and they were marked a bad school.

Soon, children from these 'bad schools' were being rescued from them, and their schools began losing more and more funding, and became the bad schools they'd originally been labeled as. The students were bussed to better schools, that then received more funding, that they didn't need, since they were already a high-income, well-testing school.

So now, the good schools are better, and the decent schools are bad, and the bad schools are horrible, while the private schools have remained expensive and perfectly fine. Some students are excelling, while thousands more, in low-income schools that happened to test poorly, are being left far behind. I wonder if that prominent, well-to-do Caucasian man will ever realize his act is failing more

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students than it's helping?

I doubt it.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: RedLipsandTattoos (pen name)
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No Child Left Behind
by Dominique Christina and Denice Frohman

An entrance to a west Philadelphia high school.

Officer with gun perched on each waist,

Asks me if I have any weapons.

I hold up my book,

He doesn't find that funny.

Tells me to empty pockets and walk through the metal detector.

8: 03 am,

I wait for two students to pass through the metal detector first,

Already wondering if they have learned anything at all.

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I heard that the newly built prison a few miles away
Bought the test scores of failing schools to use as wallpaper.
But we say no child left behind.
Cause it's a slogan for the slick.
To convince you that you have not heard it before.
Like your momma did not work three jobs,
Average two hours of sleep a night,
So you would not be left behind.
No child left behind is a bumper sticker, a caption,
An empty slogan with no room for imagination.
So our teacher asked if we have dreams.
11 students raise their hands barley above their shoulders,
As if they were sitting in history class unsure of the right answer.
But there is no right answer I say,
And they are far too comfortable with the right to remain silent.
I'm escorted to an auditorium
Where there are 130 other black and Latino students.
We talk about hip hop.
They think poetry is what old white people do.

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I tell them my favorite poem is "Miss Fat Booty,"
Cause I like the story telling.
They giggle as if they're still kids,
Cause kids these days tie poetry to a chair and they torture it with bad hip hop,
They flog and they beat it,
They trick and B-E-T it,
Deny it food water and light,
Then figure out how to booty shake to it.
No child left behind even when the culture is sick
The first time I read a book by a black author was in college,
The wind in my chest stood up,
It had been 18 long years of textbooks filled with everything but me.
See the quickest way to silence a mouth
Is to treat it as if no one had come before.
There are thousands of unreported lynchings,
That happen in American classrooms each year.
The victims are between the ages of five and nineteen
They are black, and brown, and poor, and different,
Round pegs in square classrooms.
Children suffering for not being who we want them to be.

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For having voices too loud,

accents too thick,

pockets too thin,

For our classrooms to honor us --

just as we are.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Dominique Christina & Denice Frohman
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Video of performance by the poets at the College Unions Poetry Slam Invitational in Boulder, Colorado in March 2014 can be found here
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=RHSqUyi6GUU&list=PLC5PJtWBiqV0NAqi2V2vbyqmpuJU1dURm&index=5

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